

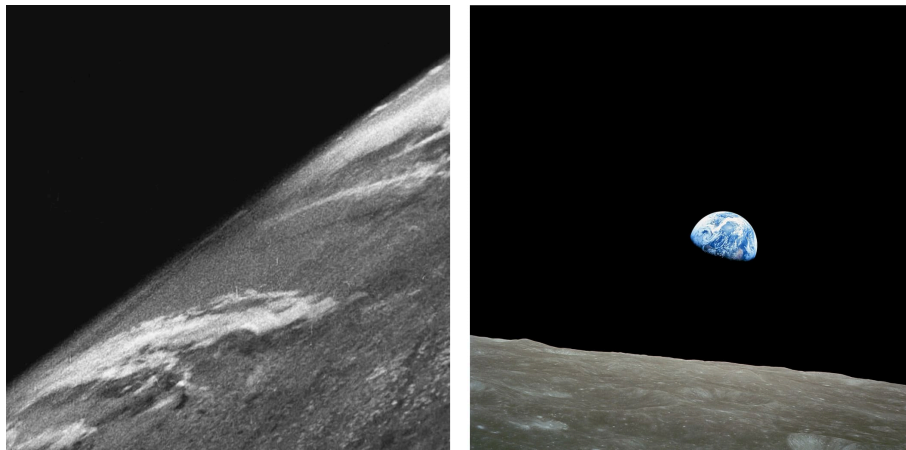
Session 6: Genesis 1 Is an Ancient Israelite Cosmology

Key Takeaways

- In Hebrew, the word for “earth” typically means “land,” rather than a globe or sphere floating in space. So when you read Genesis 1, imagine the story communicating about the land the people live on.
- God names the *raqiaʿ* the *shamayim*—the Hebrew word for “skies” or “heavens.”
- In the Bible, the *raqiaʿ* is the solid dome above the land that holds back the waters above, and the creation of the *raqiaʿ* creates a place where life can flourish.
- In the biblical view, God graciously sustains the *raqiaʿ*, keeping its floodgates closed so that the Earth will never again be destroyed (Gen. 9:11).

“Earth” in Genesis 1:1-2

In Hebrew, *ʾerets* (אֶרֶץ) does not mean “globe-earth.” This is a modern meaning of the English word “earth” that depends on the concept of the planet as a sphere. This concept was not available to the biblical authors at the time.



Left image: U.S. Army (1946). [Wikimedia Commons](#). Right image: Anders, William (1968). [Wikimedia Commons](#)

These photos are fascinating but totally irrelevant for understanding what the ancient Hebrew word *ʾerets* means in Genesis 1.

There are no uses of *ʾerets* in the Hebrew Bible that describe the land as a sphere. Rather, the word’s meaning describes the land that is below the skies and the clouds.

For [God] looked down from his holy height; from heaven the LORD gazed upon the **'erets**.

Psalms 103:11 NASB

For as high as the heavens are above the **'erets**, so great is his lovingkindness toward those who fear him.

By looking at the biblical usage of *'erets*, we can see that a more appropriate English word for translating *'erets* would be "land."

"Firmament/Expanse/Vault/Dome" in Genesis 1:6-8

In Hebrew, *raqia'* refers to a solid blue dome above the land, above which are presumed to be waters. The English word "dome" is an accurate rendering of the word based on its other uses in the biblical text.

The Noun *Raqia'*

Genesis 1:6-8 NASB*

⁶ And God said, "Let there be a ***raqia'*** in the midst of the waters, and let it separate the waters from the water." ⁷ God made the ***raqia'***, and separated the water which were below the ***raqia'*** from the waters which were above the ***raqia'***; and it was so. ⁸ God called the ***raqia'*** "heavens." And there was evening and there was morning, a second day.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 1:20 NASB*

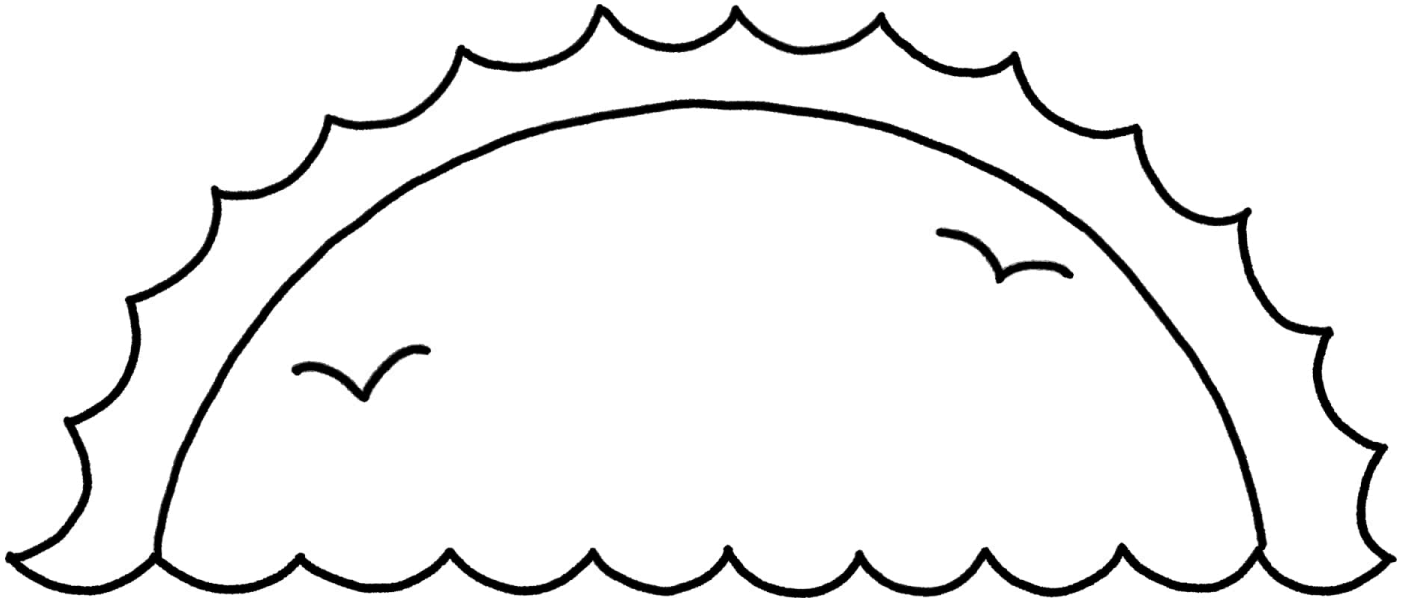
And God said, "... and let the birds fly over the land against the surface of the ***raqia'*** ..."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Ezekiel 1:22, 26 NASB*

²² And there was something like a ***raqia'*** over the heads of the living creatures, like the appearance of ice, stretched out over their heads above ... ²⁶ and above the ***raqia'*** that was over their heads something like blue sapphire, the appearance of a throne ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher



Separation of Waters. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2019).

The Verb Raqa'

In Hebrew, *raqa'* means "to hammer out, smooth, spread out."

Exodus 39:3 NASB*

And they [the craftsmen] **raqa'd** smooth sheets of gold, and they cut them into cords to be woven together with blue and purple and scarlet ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Numbers 16:39 NASB*

So Eleazer the priest took the bronze censers which the men who were burned had offered, and they **raqa'd** them out as a plating for the altar ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 40:19 NASB*

As for the idol, a craftsman casts it, a goldsmith **raqa's** it with gold ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 42:5 NASB*

Thus says God the LORD,
who created the heavens and stretched them out,
who **raqa'd** the land and what springs up from it,

who gives breath to the people on it
and spirit to those who walk in it ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The Windows of the Raqia'

The *raqia'* is a solid blue dome between the land and the cosmic waters, which are released over the land through windows in the *raqia'*.

Genesis 7:11 NASB*

In the sixth hundreth year of Noah's life, in the second month, on the seventeenth day of the month, on the same day all the fountains of the great deep burst open, and **the windows of the skies** were opened.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Reflection Question

What does the word "earth" mean in the biblical text? What is the *raqia'*, and what does it do?